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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1954-1957

Coverage Date: 1930-1957

Place Coverage

Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Chapter 7 Recreation

Although Nyansongo women participate in the men's beer parties, this cannot be called their major form of recreation. The women more frequently mix pleasure with their work, which is very demanding and time consuming. While men meet over beer, women come together daily in their cooperative working teams, which give them the opportunity to chat, gossip, and joke with one another while cultivating the fields. In the afternoon, when they relax a bit or do some chores around the house like spreading grain on mats to dry, one or two women may drop in on another and spend some time talking. If she goes to the power mill, a woman engages in conversation while waiting in line to have her maize ground. However, going to the market in town or beyond one or two days a week is the greatest recreational event for a Nyansongo married woman. She gets dressed up in her best clothes and goes with a group of her female neighbors. There is always an economic justification for the trip—exchanging grain or vegetables for money, pots, or chickens—and a 15- to 20-mile walk is often involved, but seeing the town, looking over European goods in the shops, and the good-natured banter en route provide enjoyment over and above its ostensible purpose.

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Apart from their weekly routine, married women conduct the most elaborate and raucous ceremonies in Nyansongo life. The initiation of girls, described later, is an annual revel for the females in the community, and they violate proprieties on that occasion as men never do. Initiation of female diviners, which occurs less regularly, provides another occasion for great rejoicing and, like initiation of girls, involves singing, dancing, and feasts. Unlike the latter, however, the festivities of diviners' initiation are held mainly indoors, and men must drop some money at the entrance in order to be welcome. The gayest and most elaborate indoor party attended by the ethnographers in Nyansongo was a diviners' initiation.

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In ceremonies conducted by men, women often take a lighthearted attitude which is recreational for them and inconsistent with the seriousness of the males in charge. At the sacrifice of a goat to the spirit of a recently deceased Nyansongo homestead head, the women scrambled with each other for the pieces of meat allowed them. They devoured the raw intestines and forequarters voraciously, then complained about not getting more. The widow of the deceased took the lead in this good-humored fun, while the men solemnly performed the ritual and divided the meat according to traditional prescription. The female  65 tendency to be boisterous in a formal ritual setting is also exhibited during the leading-in ceremony of the male initiation rites (see Chapter 16) and in the traditional marriage ceremony as described here and in Mayer (1950a). Women are expected to be highly expressive and even obstructive on such occasions.

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